

Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in Milan, Italy



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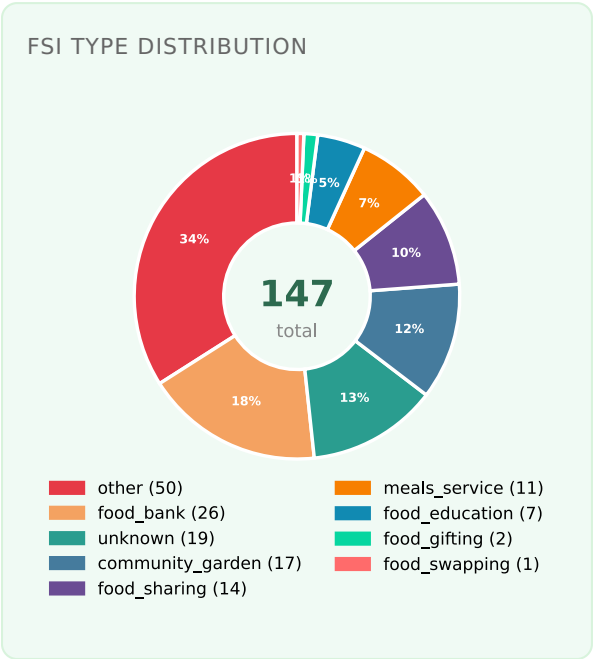
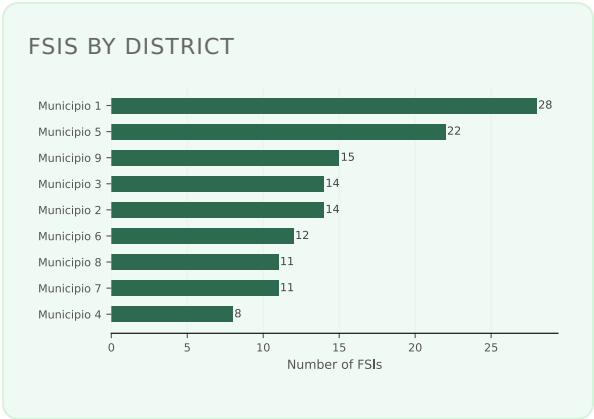
Io non butto - CSV Lombardia
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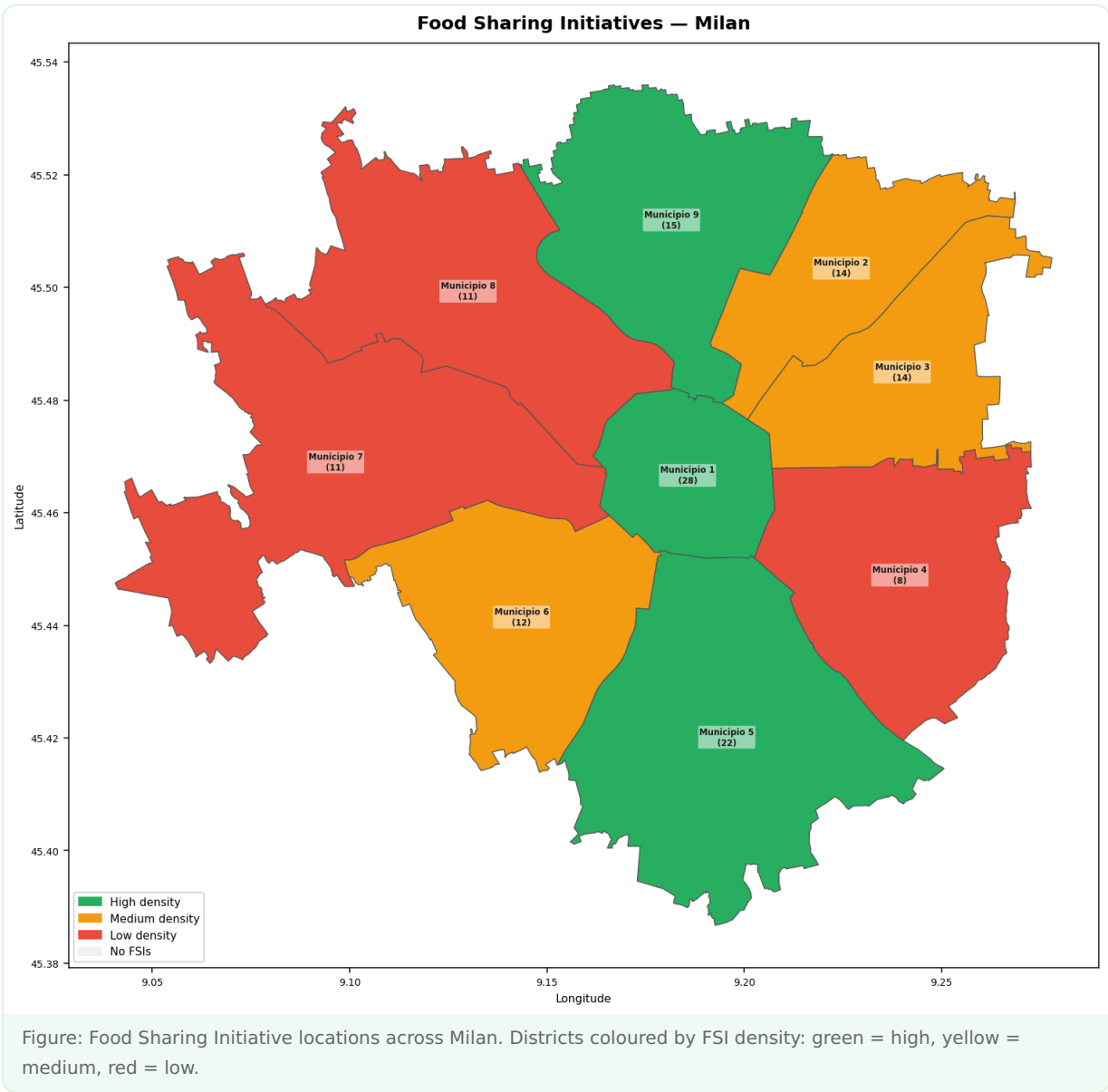
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Geographic Distribution



Milan hosts 147 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) across its nine postal districts, with the highest concentrations found in Municipio 1 (28 FSIs), Municipio 5 (22 FSIs), and Municipio 9 (15 FSIs), which together account for 34% of all FSIs in the city. These three districts, designated as "green" (high-density) areas, collectively house 65 FSIs, reflecting a marked disparity in initiative distribution compared to other districts. No district in Milan has fewer than eight FSIs, with the lowest-count entries (Municipio 4 and Municipio 7) still hosting 11 and 11 FSIs respectively. The spatial clustering of FSIs in green districts suggests a correlation between urban density and the prevalence of such initiatives, though this relationship remains unquantified due to missing per capita data.

Comparing district categories, green districts (Municipio 1, 5, 9) exhibit the highest FSI counts, with Municipio 1 alone hosting 28 FSIs—nearly double the number in the next-highest district (Municipio 5). Yellow districts (Municipio 3, 2, 6), which contain 14, 14, and 12 FSIs respectively, show moderate density but lack the concentration seen in green areas.

Red districts (Municipio 8, 7, 4), with 11, 11, and 8 FSIs, have the lowest counts but still maintain multiple initiatives, indicating that even lower-density areas sustain FSIs. The absence of districts with only one FSI highlights a citywide trend of clustered rather than isolated initiatives, though the lack of population data prevents analysis of per capita participation rates. This uneven distribution may reflect varying levels of community engagement or resource availability across districts.

Types of Food Sharing Initiatives

Milan hosts 147 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with the majority (50, or 34.0%) categorized as "other," reflecting a broad and diverse range of activities beyond formal food redistribution. Food banks constitute the second-largest group (26, 17.7%), followed by community gardens (17, 11.6%) and food-sharing programs (14, 9.5%). Notably, 71 FSIs (48.3%) emphasize sustainability, while 24 (16.3%) integrate educational components, highlighting a growing alignment between food sharing and environmental or learning objectives. Over three-quarters of FSIs (92, 62.6%) organize events or workshops, underscoring their role as community hubs for engagement and knowledge exchange.

The distribution of FSIs by type reveals contrasts in focus and scale: while "other" initiatives dominate, niche categories like food gifting (2, 1.4%) and food swapping (1, 0.7%) remain rare, suggesting limited formalization of these practices. Sustainability-focused FSIs outnumber those with educational components by nearly threefold, indicating a stronger emphasis on environmental goals than on pedagogical outreach. Among event-organizing FSIs, food banks and community gardens may disproportionately contribute to public engagement, given their structured operations, whereas smaller or informal initiatives might prioritize localized, less publicized activities. The high participation in events (62.6%) contrasts with the relatively low presence of educational programs, potentially signaling gaps in integrating learning outcomes into food-sharing practices.

Operational and Funding Models

Milan hosts 147 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with the majority (141) being non-commercial, encompassing voluntary or charitable efforts. Of these, 63 are NGO-led, accounting for 43% of all FSIs, while 21 are community-led grassroots projects, reflecting a strong emphasis on local participation. Government and council support remain limited, with only 14 government-funded and 3 council-supported initiatives, highlighting a reliance on non-state actors. Five FSIs incorporate crowdfunding or donations, indicating a partial reliance on external financial support despite the dominance of voluntary models.

NGO-led initiatives outnumber community-led ones by nearly threefold, yet community groups manage 3 informally run projects, suggesting varying levels of formalization. The cooperative model is utilized by 31 FSIs, a significant share that may reflect collaborative governance structures. Notably, 48 FSIs are formally registered as NGOs or charities, while 6 are affiliated with broader food networks, potentially enhancing their resource access or visibility. In contrast, no FSIs are volunteer-based, underscoring the absence of purely unpaid labor models despite the prevalence of non-commercial operations. This contrast

may indicate strategic integration of funding mechanisms or structural dependencies within Milan's FSI landscape.

Reach and Activity

Milan hosts 147 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs), with 104 classified as high activity and 43 as low activity, indicating a significant disparity in operational intensity. The total quantified volume of food redistributed across these initiatives amounts to 31,308 units, reflecting a substantial contribution to reducing food waste in the city. Notably, 42 FSIs collaborate with farms, restaurants, or stores, suggesting a structured network for sourcing surplus food. This collaboration appears critical, as it likely enhances the scale and sustainability of food redistribution efforts compared to initiatives operating independently.

The absence of medium activity FSIs highlights a binary distribution between high and low performers, with no intermediate level of engagement observed. Target audiences are unevenly distributed, with elderly individuals comprising the largest group (32 mentions) followed by students (14 mentions), while children and general audiences are far less frequently cited (2 and 8 mentions, respectively). This contrast implies that initiatives may prioritize older populations or educational settings over younger demographics or broader community outreach. The lack of medium activity FSIs could signal either a lack of resources for scaling up or a concentration of efforts in either highly active or minimally active models. Meanwhile, the 42 collaborating FSIs may represent a strategic subset focused on systemic food waste reduction, though their specific impact remains unquantified in the data.

Digital Presence and Accessibility

All 147 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in Milan have a digital presence, as evidenced by website scraping data, indicating a strong reliance on online platforms for coordination and outreach. Of these, 70 FSIs explicitly mention online or digital coordination methods, suggesting a significant portion integrates technology into their operations. In contrast, only 19 FSIs operate from physical locations, highlighting a disparity between digital and in-person engagement. Furthermore, just 5 FSIs list operating hours or frequency, underscoring a widespread lack of transparency regarding logistical details that could aid user participation.

The data reveals a marked contrast between FSIs with robust digital infrastructure and those with limited operational transparency. While 70 FSIs leverage online coordination, the 19 physical-location FSIs may cater to more localized or community-based activities, though their absence of detailed operating schedules could hinder accessibility. Notably, the lack of consistent accessibility features on FSI websites—such as screen-reader compatibility or language options—raises concerns about inclusivity, despite cross-lingual processing enabling English summaries of Italian-language content. This gap suggests that while digital presence is universal, the quality and usability of online resources remain uneven,

potentially limiting engagement among non-English speakers or individuals with disabilities.

Notable Initiatives

Milan hosts 147 Food Sharing Initiatives (FSIs) in total, with the highest concentrations located in Municipio 1 (28 FSIs), Municipio 5 (22 FSIs), and Municipio 9 (15 FSIs), reflecting uneven geographic distribution. Of these, 104 FSIs (70.7% of the total) are classified as high-popularity, indicating widespread engagement or visibility. Additionally, 24 FSIs (16.3% of the total) incorporate educational components, while 92 (62.6% of the total) regularly organise events, suggesting a focus on community interaction and outreach. These figures highlight the diversity of FSI models, with some prioritising knowledge dissemination and others emphasising social cohesion through events.

Comparing sub-groups, FSIs with educational components are less numerous than those hosting events, yet their presence in 16.3% of initiatives suggests a niche but significant role in promoting awareness about food waste and sustainability. In contrast, the 92 event-organising FSIs likely contribute more directly to local social networks and public engagement. Municipio 1, home to 28 FSIs, outpaces the combined total of Municipio 5 and 9 (37 FSIs) by 11 initiatives, indicating a disproportionately high level of activity in this district. This disparity may reflect differences in urban density, policy support, or community demand across districts. The data also implies that while high-popularity FSIs dominate in numbers, their coexistence with smaller, specialised initiatives underscores the multifaceted nature of food sharing in Milan.